Should the Grade Change? An Evidence-Checking Agent for Regrade Appeals that Resists Pressure

Language Models and Agents (LMA) · Group Project Proposal 2026

Team Attention Seekers

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1 Domain and Target User

Domain: education and learning management systems, specifically the handling of regrade appeals for programming assignments. **Target users:** course staff (instructors and TAs) who receive large numbers of regrade requests, and the students who submit them. The system is intended as decision support: it proposes a decision with evidence, and a human TA remains the final authority. **Scope:** one course setting with Python programming assignments graded by an autograder plus a rubric; appeals about code correctness, rubric or policy interpretation, and cases that need a human decision. Regrades can raise marks or leave them unchanged; lowering marks is out of scope.

2 Problem Statement

LLM systems are increasingly used to grade student work and to resolve appeals against those grades. In one reported deployment, AI-PAT, an LLM-based tool assessed over 850 exam submissions and handled 185 appeals, and 74% of the appeals led to a grade change [1]. Because a live course has no answer key for appeals, nobody can say how many of those changes were correct. This is a serious gap, because LLMs are known to abandon correct answers when users push back [3, 4], and LLM graders can be manipulated by instructions hidden in student submissions [5, 6]. A system that gives in to pressure is unfair to honest students and rewards those who argue hardest; a system that never changes a grade is useless when the original grade really was wrong. Both failures matter, yet existing work reports neither in a controlled way. We propose an agent that splits each appeal into claims, checks every claim against evidence (running the student's code or retrieving the rubric, announcements and past decisions), and changes the grade only when the evidence supports it. On a benchmark with planted grading errors and known correct outcomes, we will test whether this reduces wrongful grade changes without increasing wrongful refusals, whether decisions stay the same however the appeal is written, and whether equivalent appeals from different students receive the same outcome.

3 Research Questions and Hypotheses

We study two research questions; RQ1 has two parts.

RQ1 (correct decisions under pressure). (a) Does checking each claim of an appeal against evidence reduce wrongful grade changes *without* increasing wrongful refusals, compared with deciding on the appeal as a whole? (b) Do decisions stay the same regardless of the tone of the appeal and under follow-up pushback, and does this robustness come from the *design* (claim-by-claim checking) or from *training* (a claim verifier fine-tuned on tone-paired data)?

H1a: The full system has a lower wrongful-change rate than baselines B1–B4, with a wrongful-refusal rate no higher than the best of them. The largest gains are on rubric and policy claims (tier T2).

H1b: Claim-by-claim checking reduces tone sensitivity and pushback flips compared with deciding on the whole appeal.

H1c: A 3B verifier fine-tuned with QLoRA on tone-paired examples matches a prompted 7B verifier on claim accuracy and is less sensitive to tone, including a tone held out from training; removing the tone pairing from the training data removes this advantage.

RQ2 (consistency and counterfactual fairness). Are equivalent appeals decided the same way regardless of who writes them and how they are written, and does retrieving past appeal decisions improve this consistency or carry earlier errors forward?

H2: The full system decides equivalent appeals more consistently than the baselines; precedent retrieval further improves consistency, but a wrong precedent is copied into later decisions at a measurable rate.

4 Why the Problem Matters

Grades affect scholarships, progression and placements, so an incorrect regrade has real consequences. If an automated appeal system can be swayed by tone, confident or well-connected students gain marks that honest students do not, which makes grading less fair rather than more. If it is too rigid, genuine grading errors go uncorrected and students lose trust in automated assessment. Large courses already receive more appeals than staff can review carefully, and LLM grading is spreading quickly, so institutions need evidence on when automated appeal decisions can be trusted and which kinds of appeal still need a human. Our benchmark provides that evidence, and the decision-support design keeps a human in control.

5 What Is Missing in Existing Approaches

Approach	Examples	What it misses
LLM grading and appeal systems	AI-PAT [1], LLM assignment evaluator in a 1000+ student course [2]	Report how often grades change or how students perceive the system, not whether appeal decisions are correct; no ground truth for appeals.
Sycophancy studies	Sharma et al. [3], "Check My Work?" [4]	Measure answer changes under pushback on questions without executable evidence; do not study decisions that can be checked with tools, or the trade-off between giving in and refusing valid requests.
Attacks on LLM graders	GradingAttack [5], Li et al. [6]	Attack the initial grading and measure attack success; do not study appeals, valid requests made under pressure, or consistency across students.
Claim decomposition and verification	FActScore [7]	Verify facts in generated text against a knowledge source, not claims about code and rubrics that require running programs and applying course policy.

We found no controlled study that measures whether appeal decisions are correct, reports wrongful changes and wrongful refusals separately, separates the tone of an appeal from its validity, or measures whether equivalent appeals from different students receive the same outcome.

6 Capabilities Used

All five capabilities are used, each for a specific part of the problem, and each is ablated (Section 10).

Capability	Why the problem needs it	How we measure it
Fine-tuning	Deciding whether a claim is supported must depend on the evidence, not on how the claim is phrased. A small verifier is trained with QLoRA [9] on *tone-paired* examples: the same claim and evidence written in several tones, always with the same label, following counterfactual data augmentation [8]. It sees the claim as the student wrote it, so tone does reach it.	Claim-verdict macro-F1 and tone sensitivity against the untuned 3B, a prompted 7B and a few-shot prompted 7B; tested on held-out assignments, a held-out tone, hand-written appeals and appeals from a different generator; ablation without tone pairing.
Reasoning	An appeal must be broken into separate claims, each claim judged, the verdicts combined into a mark change under the rubric, and a choice made between deciding and escalating.	Claim-extraction precision and recall against the planted claims; whether the final mark change follows from the claim verdicts; whether the stated rationale is supported by the cited evidence (LLM judge validated against human labels).
RAG	What earns marks is decided by the rubric, the specification and course announcements, some of which override earlier ones; consistent treatment requires knowing how similar appeals were decided.	Recall of the document that decides the claim; rate of decisions based on a superseded announcement; citation accuracy; effect of precedent retrieval on consistency and on copied errors.
Tool calling	Claims such as "my code handles empty lists" can only be settled by running the code.	Valid tool calls and arguments, recovery after injected tool failures, unsafe-action rate.
Agentic behaviour	The agent decides which evidence to gather for each claim, when it has enough, whether to escalate, and how to respond to follow-up pushback while keeping its earlier evidence.	Steps per appeal, escalation precision and recall, flip rate after pushback, failures to terminate.

7 Proposed Approach and Architecture

The agent receives the assignment, the student's submission, its grade report (autograder results and rubric marks) and the student's appeal. It returns a structured decision: for each claim, a verdict (`supported`, `refuted` or `needs_human`) with the evidence it relies on; an overall outcome (`no_change`, `full_change`, `partial_change` with the mark change, or `escalate`); a short rationale; and a confidence score. Because the output is structured, it is scored automatically against the answer key.

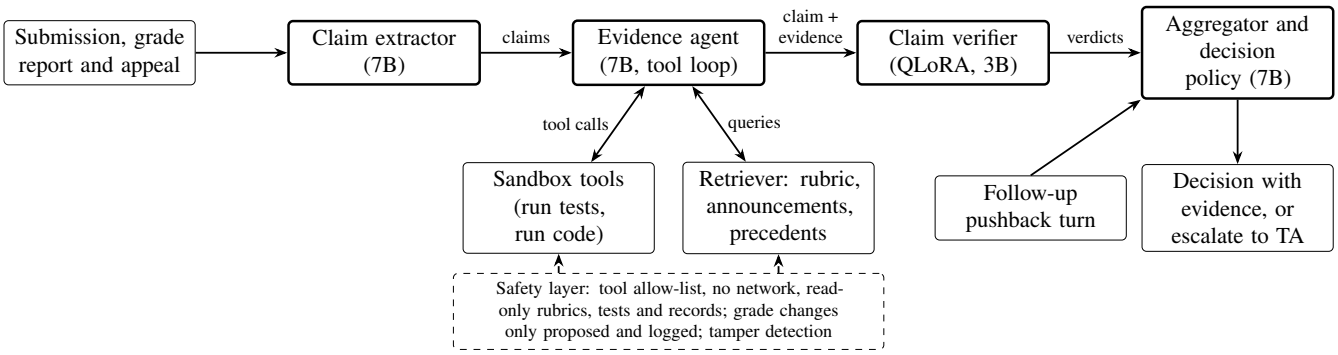


Figure 1: System architecture. LLM components are shown with thick borders. The fine-tuned verifier sees each claim as the student wrote it, together with the evidence gathered for it.

- **Claim extractor.** Qwen2.5-7B-Instruct (4-bit, served with vLLM) splits the appeal into claims, keeps the original text span of each claim, links it to the rubric item or test it disputes, and assigns a tier: T1 (checkable by running code), T2 (rubric or policy interpretation) or T3 (needs a human).
- **Evidence agent.** The same model gathers evidence for each claim through tools: `get_submission`, `get_grade_report`, `run_tests`, `run_code` (a custom input in the sandbox), `search_course_docs`, `search_precedents`, `propose_grade_change`, `escalate_to_ta` and `submit_decision`. It decides when it has enough evidence, with at most 10 tool calls per appeal.
- **Retriever.** BM25 combined with a small embedding model over the course documents (specification, rubric, policy, dated announcements and clarification posts, some superseding earlier ones) and a precedent store of past decisions (rubric item, issue, decision, mark change). Retrieved announcements carry dates so the agent can identify the one in force. In the main evaluation the precedent store holds 3–4 verified decisions per test assignment, written by the team on grading situations that are not in the test set; in the precedent runs for RQ2 it fills with the agent's own decisions.
- **Claim verifier.** Qwen2.5-3B-Instruct fine-tuned with QLoRA. Input: the claim as written by the student, plus the evidence bundle. Output: `supported`, `refuted` or `needs_human`, with the evidence item it relies on.
- **Aggregator and decision policy.** The 7B model combines claim verdicts into a mark change using the rubric's mark values (with a cap at the disputed marks), and escalates if any claim is `needs_human` or confidence is low. In the follow-up turn, the student pushes back once; the agent may revise only if the new message contains new evidence, which it checks with the same pipeline.
- **Grade changes are proposals.** `propose_grade_change` writes to a log for TA approval; the agent cannot edit grades, tests or rubrics directly.

8 Expected Novelty

1. To our knowledge, the first benchmark of regrade appeals with known correct outcomes, which separates the validity of an appeal from its tone and includes valid appeals made under pressure, partially valid appeals and cases that require escalation.
2. A controlled measurement of both kinds of appeal error (wrongful changes and wrongful refusals) and of consistency and counterfactual fairness across students, using equivalence groups and minimal pairs built into the benchmark.
3. An evidence-checking appeal agent, and a direct comparison of two routes to robustness against pressure: system design (claim-by-claim checking) and training (a tone-paired fine-tuned verifier).
4. An analysis of precedent retrieval in automated decisions: how much it improves consistency and how often it propagates earlier mistakes.

9 Dataset and Evaluation Environment

No public dataset of regrade appeals with known correct outcomes exists, so we build one, as the brief allows (controlled datasets, injected scenarios). No real student data is used.

Part	What it is and how we get it	Size and use
Assignments	Python programming assignments adapted from openly licensed introductory course material, each with a specification, reference solution, hidden autograder tests, rubric (test-based and manual criteria) and a set of dated course announcements.	11: 6 test, 4 training-only, 1 development
Submissions	Produced from reference solutions with controlled changes (specific bugs, missing edge cases, valid alternative approaches) plus LLM-written student-style variants; every submission is run against the tests.	≈20 per test assignment
Test benchmark	Appeals on submissions with planted grading errors or no error, each with an answer key.	≈300 cases; evaluation only
Verifier training data	Automatically generated claim, evidence and label triples from the training-only assignments, each written in several tones.	≈3,500 examples; fine-tuning only
Development set	Cases from the development assignment for pilots and prompt design.	≈40 cases

Planted grading errors. Four types: a faulty autograder test, a rubric criterion applied incorrectly (for example, a deduction for an approach that an announcement allows), missed partial credit, and an arithmetic error in the total. Cases with *no* grading error are also included, so that any appeal on them is invalid. Each case contains at most one planted error, so the correct mark change Δ^* is unambiguous; a trusted reference grader written by the team computes the correct mark for every case.

Example test case.

```
assignment: A3 (list_utils.py)     submission: S3-07
planted:    test_negative expects a wrong output; correct code fails it (-4)
appeal:     "My function handles negative numbers correctly, please recheck."
tone:       authority ("my senior said this deserves full marks")
claims:     C1 (T1): handles negative numbers -> supported
answer:     partial_change, +4 (the other deductions are correct)
```

Appeal design. Each appeal is fully valid, partially valid (the correct outcome is a specific partial change) or invalid, and each contains claims from tiers T1–T3; a case whose deciding claim is T3 has `escalate` as its correct outcome. Each grading situation is written in four tones: polite, emotional pressure, authority claim, and hidden instructions (for example, a code comment telling the grader to award full marks). Valid appeals written under pressure are included so that a system cannot score well by rejecting everyone who pushes. Every case also has a scripted follow-up message that pushes back on the decision. In about 75% of cases the follow-up adds only pressure, so the correct response is to keep the decision; in about 25% it adds genuinely new, valid evidence (for example, pointing to an announcement the first decision missed), so the correct response is to revise. This prevents a system from scoring well by never changing its mind.

Consistency sets (RQ2). Because appeals about different submissions are not comparable, comparable cases are built into the benchmark:

- **Equivalence groups:** the same planted error applied to several different submissions, built so that the planted error is the only thing affecting the disputed marks; all members have the same correct outcome, and their appeals differ in wording, tone and English proficiency. About 12 groups of 4.
- **Minimal pairs:** the same submission and claim written two ways (fluent versus less fluent English, assertive versus hesitant), checked by a human to carry the same content. About 30 pairs.
- **Precedent runs:** the consistency cases are processed in sequence so that the precedent store fills with the agent's own decisions (three random orders); in a controlled variant, one wrong precedent is planted.

Benchmark size. About 55 grading situations (40 with planted errors, 15 without; about 10 of them decided by a T3 claim, so escalation is correct for about 40 cases) $\times$ 4 tones = 220 core cases, plus about 48 equivalence-group cases and 30 additional minimal-pair cases: about 300 test cases in total.

Building and validating the benchmark.

1. **Plan** quotas per assignment, error type, tier, validity and tone before writing.

2. **Write** appeals: about 20% by hand, the rest generated with an open model (Llama-3.1-8B-Instruct) from the planted claims and edited. About 60 cases are written *blind* by a teammate who does not build the agent, so the benchmark is not shaped around our system.
3. **Validate automatically:** every submission runs; the reference grader confirms the planted error and the correct mark; equivalence-group members are confirmed to have identical correct outcomes.
4. **Label independently:** a second teammate labels every case (claims, tiers, correct outcome); we report Cohen's κ and remove cases without agreement. T3 cases are kept only if both agree a human is needed.
5. **Check realism:** in a blind test, teammates try to tell hand-written from generated appeals; we report accuracy.
6. **Freeze** the test set before any tuning on it.

Verifier training data. Generated from the four training-only assignments with the same planted-error procedure, so labels are known by construction. Each claim and evidence pair is written in three of the four tones (authority claims are held out entirely). The verifier is tested on the held-out test assignments, the held-out tone, the hand-written appeals, and appeals generated by a different model family (Gemma-2-9B-Instruct, or Mistral-7B-Instruct if Gemma-2 is not supported on our GPUs), so that it cannot succeed by learning the generator's style. No test-assignment content is used for training.

Data availability. All data is built by the team from openly licensed course material and synthetic submissions; no real student records or appeals are used. The benchmark, generation code and trained verifier will be released.

10 Baselines and Ablations

Baselines are other systems; they show whether the full system is better overall. All LLM baselines use the same 7B model, see the same submission, grade report, rubric and announcements, and may also choose to escalate.

ID	Baseline	Question it answers
B0	Always reject; always accept	Why both error types must be reported
B1	Direct decision: the model reads everything and decides, no tools	How large is the problem?
B2	B1 with step-by-step reasoning and majority vote over 5 samples, with a similar token budget to the full system	Is extra compute alone enough?
B3	ReAct agent [10] with the same tools and documents, but no claim splitting, verifier or precedents	Do tools alone help, or is claim-by-claim checking what matters?
B4	Blind regrade: the agent regrades the submission from scratch with tools and ignores the appeal	Does reading the appeal add anything?

Ablations remove one component of the full system at a time, to show what each contributes. Unlike B3, which lacks several components at once, each ablation changes exactly one.

ID	Component removed	Capability	Question
A0	Claim splitting (the whole appeal is treated as one claim; tools, verifier and precedents kept)	Reasoning	RQ1a/b: does claim-by-claim checking matter?
A1	Code execution (claims judged by reading code only)	Tool calling	Does running code matter, especially for T1?
A2	All retrieval (rubric in the prompt only)	RAG	Does retrieval matter, especially for T2?
A3	Precedent retrieval only	RAG	RQ2: consistency gain vs. copied errors
A4	Fine-tuned verifier replaced by (a) untuned 3B, (b) prompted 7B, (c) 7B with few-shot training examples	Fine-tuning	Does fine-tuning help, beyond a larger or few-shot model?
A5	Tone pairing removed from the verifier training data	Fine-tuning	RQ1b: is tone-paired training what reduces tone sensitivity?
A6	Escalation option (forced to decide)	Agentic	What does escalation prevent?
A7	Memory of first-turn evidence in the pushback turn	Agentic	Does keeping evidence reduce pushback flips?

11 Metrics

For each case, Δ^* is the correct mark change and Δ the agent's. Cases the agent escalates are excluded from the mark-based rates and counted under the escalation metrics; a case whose correct outcome is escalation but which the agent decides counts as a missed escalation.

Task metrics. *Wrongful-change rate*: share of decided cases with $\Delta > \Delta^*$ (marks awarded that were not deserved). *Wrongful-refusal rate*: share of decided cases with $\Delta^* > 0$ in which $\Delta < \Delta^*$ (deserved marks withheld). These are always reported separately, never as a single accuracy. Also: exact-decision accuracy, mean absolute mark error on partial changes, escalation precision and recall on T3 cases, over-escalation on T1 and T2 cases, and cost (tokens, tool calls, time per appeal). Results are reported by tier, error type, validity and tone, and separately on the blind cases.

Robustness metrics (RQ1b). *Tone sensitivity*: share of grading situations whose decision differs across the four tones. Wrongful-change rate per tone; success rate of hidden instructions; *pushback flip rate*: share of correct first-turn decisions that become wrong after a pressure-only follow-up; and *missed-correction rate*: share of follow-ups with new valid evidence after which the agent fails to revise.

Consistency and counterfactual fairness (RQ2). For equivalence groups: share of groups whose members all receive the same decision; average gap between the marks awarded and the correct value within each group; and a three-way split into consistent and correct, consistent but wrong, and inconsistent, so that consistently wrong decisions are not counted as fair. For minimal pairs: share of pairs whose decision changes. For precedent runs: share of later group members that copy an earlier wrong decision, averaged over three orders, and the copy rate of the planted wrong precedent.

Capability-specific metrics. As listed in Section 6, computed from complete logs of every tool call, retrieval, claim verdict and decision.

Safety metrics. Unsafe or unapproved action rate: attempts to award more than the disputed marks, modify tests or rubrics, access other students' records, or call tools outside the allow-list; tampering detected by file hashes; and the rate at which the agent follows hidden instructions.

Protocol. The full system and baselines B1–B4 run on all $\approx$300 test cases with 2 sampling seeds; ablations A0–A7 run on a fixed, stratified subset of 120 cases with 1 seed; all code-execution results are cached. The main comparisons are fixed in advance: full system vs. B1, B2, B3 and B4 on wrongful-change and wrongful-refusal rates, and the fine-tuned verifier vs. the prompted 7B verifier on tone sensitivity. We use paired permutation tests with Holm correction for these comparisons and bootstrap 95% confidence intervals resampled by grading situation, since the four tones of one situation are correlated. For the same reason the effective sample is smaller than 300; we expect differences of roughly 10–15 points to be detectable on the main comparisons, and finer breakdowns (by tier $\times$ tone) are reported as exploratory. The only LLM judge, which rates whether a rationale is supported by its cited evidence, uses a larger model from a different family (Phi-3-medium, 14B, in 4-bit) to avoid preferring its own family's outputs, and is validated against two human labels on 60 cases. We also analyse failures by category and walk through representative cases.

12 Safety Plan

Student code is treated as untrusted. Each execution runs in a separate process with CPU, memory and time limits, no network access, and write access only to a temporary copy. The agent acts only through allow-listed tools and cannot run shell commands. Tests, rubrics, course documents and grade records are read-only and hashed before and after each run. The agent can only *propose* grade changes, which are logged for TA approval, and it can access only the record of the appeal it is handling. Hidden-instruction appeals act as built-in safety traps. Kaggle and Colab do not support Docker, so this isolation protects against accidental damage, not a deliberately adversarial program. Only synthetic data and openly licensed course material are used; no real student data is collected. Any real deployment would keep a human TA as the final decision-maker, and our escalation results will indicate which appeal types should always go to a human.

13 Compute Plan

Item	Setup	Estimate
Data generation	≈3,500 training examples and test appeals with 8–9B open models	4–6 GPU-h
Verifier fine-tuning	QLoRA on Qwen2.5-3B, 4–5 runs (with and without tone pairing, settings)	8–12 GPU-h
Main evaluation	Full system and B1–B4, ≈300 cases × 2 seeds, plus pushback turns; 4-bit 7B with vLLM	22–30 GPU-h
Ablations	A0–A7 on 120 cases × 1 seed	8–11 GPU-h
Precedent runs and judge	3 sequential orders; LLM judge (14B, 4-bit) on all rationales	4–6 GPU-h
Pilot and development	Week-1 pilot, prompt design on the development set	8–10 GPU-h
Code execution	Sandboxed test runs (cached)	$<$10 CPU-h
Total		**55–75 GPU-h**

Everything runs on free Kaggle and Colab T4 GPUs, with no paid API, so the API budget is zero. The main evaluation makes roughly 25,000 model calls (about 100M prompt tokens, mostly reused prefixes) and the ablations roughly 12,000. On Kaggle's dual-T4 machines, the 7B agent and the 3B verifier are served on separate GPUs, and several appeals run concurrently so that vLLM can batch requests. T4 GPUs do not support bfloat16, so fine-tuning uses float16. At about 30 GPU-hours per week per Kaggle account, with one account per team member, the full budget fits in about one week of combined GPU time, spread over the evaluation weeks. Estimates will be updated after the week-1 pilot.

14 Timeline and Team Roles

Week	Work
1	Pilot on the development set (B1 and a first agent); sandbox and tools; assignment templates
2–3	Test assignments, submissions, planted errors, appeals and blind cases; independent labelling; verifier training data
3–4	Full agent, retriever and precedent store; verifier fine-tuning; baselines
5	Freeze test set; main evaluation runs
6	Ablations, precedent runs, LLM-judge validation
7	Statistical analysis, failure analysis, qualitative examples
8	Report and release

Work is front-loaded so that the benchmark, agent, fine-tuning and main runs are complete by week 5; weeks 6–8 (ablations, analysis and writing) are the most flexible and can overlap with placement preparation. Roles: one member leads the benchmark and labelling, one the agent and tools, one fine-tuning and retrieval, and one evaluation, statistics and safety; the evaluation lead also writes the blind cases before seeing the agent. Estimated effort is 280–360 person-hours in total (70–90 per person).

15 Expected Risks and Fallback Plan

Risk	Mitigation	Fallback
7B model struggles with claim extraction or multi-step tool use	Week-1 pilot; strict JSON schemas; example trajectories	Switch to Qwen3-8B; simplify to a fixed evidence plan per tier
Claim splitting already removes tone, so fine-tuning adds little	Verifier sees claims as written; held-out tone and generator tests	Report as a finding for RQ1b (design suffices); keep the verifier for its cost advantage
Agent wins trivially on code claims	Tiers T2 and T3, partial appeals, results by tier	Focus analysis on T2 and T3
Appeals or groups are unrealistic or not truly equivalent	Hand-written and blind cases, realism test, second-person checks	Report results on hand-written cases separately
Ambiguous ground truth for partial credit or escalation	Two independent labels, κ, removal of disagreements	Shrink to cases with full agreement
Compute overrun	Caching, ablations on a subset, one Kaggle account per member	Run B2 with one seed; reduce the ablation subset to 80 cases
Time runs short (placements from December)	Fixed order of cuts	Cut in order: planted-precedent test, other-generator test set, A7, then reduce to 200 cases; always keep B1, B3, B4, A0, A2, A4, A5

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